

2-4

Date: 2/4/2026 at 12:00

Presentation by Sharmil Desai (No presentation name)

Summary

Sharmil's talk is a deep dive about his journey from a KU graduate to the leader of a large tech exit. After early stints at large corporations like Cerner and Dell, Sharmil pivoted in 2009 to help a friend solve a practical problem: getting a restaurant's ordering system online. This side project became Menuify, a company he bootstrapped from the ground up. Because he didn't take venture capital, Sharmil mentions he learnt how to be a CEO through trial and error. This was only possible because there were no outside investors that he had to plead

A central theme of the speech is that an engineering background is a superpower for business operations. Sharmil describes how he applied technical logic to solve physical bottlenecks (an example he gave was how he built a custom Windows-based touchscreen terminal over a weekend when fax machines couldn't handle high order volumes). He also detailed using Raspberry Pi dashboards to give his support team real-time visibility and implementing "circuit breaker" logic during pandemic-era traffic spikes (like a Taco Tuesday/Cinco de Mayo overlap) to prevent system overloads. Sharmil treated business as a collection of systems and data waiting to be optimized.

By 2021, Menuify was processing millions of orders per month and generating \$25 million in annual revenue with \$14 million in EBITDA. Despite his love for the daily problem-solving, Sharmil's CFO convinced him that the post-pandemic market presented a "once-in-a-century" opportunity to sell. The exit process was a 60-day marathon of financial and technical due diligence, but led to a sale in the \$150M to \$200M range. The speaker moved from being a founder to a high-level executive overseeing multiple engineering teams for the acquiring firm.

In his concluding advice, Sharmil challenges aspiring developers to focus on being "product-minded" rather than just writing code. He argues that while AI is becoming proficient at handling boilerplate tasks like UI development (which him and I both hate), it cannot replace the human ability to understand a customer's pain and come up with something to fix it. He predicts that the specific languages you learn in school will likely be obsolete in a decade, making the ability to learn the only truly permanent skill.

Sharmil ends his talk by talking about his new venture, a project management tool called **Done**.

What I learnt

One of my biggest takeaways was how to run a business. Sharmil mentioned how he had dashboards for everything that the company did and called running a business like an

optimization problem. I haven't taken any business courses, so I wasn't sure what it is like, but the way he described it makes it sound like I could be a good fit.

I also learnt another person's opinion on coding after AI. It was very similar to what Aleksander said two days ago, but with a little more detail. The presenter mentioned how he thinks the most useful trait will be learning how to learn. Thankfully, I have read quite a few books on how to learn and I have refined my learning abilities quite a bit.

What I will do different

I think the most important thing I will do different is be more product minded. I have often found myself making a project that I find interesting and wondering what problem it could solve instead of thinking of a problem first. While this may be a bit counter-intuitive, I constrain myself into making things that I find easy enough. But from the presenter's experience of learning on the fly, I think I will be able to do the same (especially with AI). I will think more of what is a problem and how I can fix it instead of the other way around